gle, where a Famous Five-like group investigates a spate of tiger deaths at the Nagarhole Wildlife Reserve.

Another indicator of the genre's cultural dominance is the number of new writers. These include debut writers as well as practitioners better known for, say, literary fiction, producing novels that are written and marketed as crime fiction. Anita Nair's *Hot Stage* and Tanuj Solanki's Manjhi's *Mayhem* are stellar examples of the latter, as is Deepti Kapur's *Age of Vice*.

"I think anybody who has even the slightest interest in the psychology of a person will be drawn to crime fiction," says Girish Dutt Shukla. "Gangster stories are different, where there's organised crime and economic motives but I feel that most lay readers are drawn to the question of 'why would a

AN INDICATOR OF THE GENRE'S DOMINANCE IS NEW WRITERS—DEBUT WRITERS AND ESTABLISHED ONES—PRODUCING CRIME FICTION

perfectly ordinary person be driven to murder?'" Shukla's crime novel *Cold-Blooded Love* was published by Rupa a couple of years ago. A computer scientist by education, Shukla hopes to build a career writing crime fiction.

It's undeniable that crime fiction is in the middle of a cultural moment in India. What remains to be seen is whether publishers can build upon this momentum and string together an array of writers and books—look at how efficiently Nordic crime fiction (Jo Nesbo, Asa Larsson et al) has been marketed globally. Hopefully, we can pull off something similar and bring Indian crime writers to the attention of readers around the world. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha



SHATTERED
A Memoir
By Hanif Kureishi
PENGUIN
₹999; 322 pages

BOOKS ▼

Down But Not Out

HANIF KUREISHI'S MEMOIR OF A SUDDEN FALL THAT LEFT HIM PARALYSED IS A TALE OF RESILIENCE AGAINST ALL ODDS

On Boxing Day in 2022, the British-Pakistani writer Hanif Kureishi had a sudden fall while holidaying in Rome with his partner Isabella d'Amico. Kureishi had suffered a severe spinal injury that left him paralysed, unable to walk, feed himself or hold a pen. From an active 68-year-old father of three sons with a vigorous intellectual life, he became wholly dependent, undergoing slow, agonising rehab. Although his speech and brain remained unaffected, he was moved eventually to two hospitals in England. Over the course of a year, Kureishi began to dictate regular blog posts to Isabella, and his sons Carlo, Sachin and Kier, and post them online as *The Kureishi Chronicles*.

Shattered is an edited version of those diaries, of his often degrading hospital routine—a life of catheters, daily bowel excavation, and repetitive interaction—interspersed with memories of his past life. These are the unsentimental and witty observations of an accomplished storyteller.

He is now determined not to let "the constant realisation that I am disabled" wear him down. Exhuming his past life leads to musings on literature and friendships ("My friend Salman Rushdie...writes to me every day, encouraging patience"), his long engagement with psychoanalysis ("My analyst knows me better than anyone else") and his changed relationships.

Finally, Kureishi returns home to a house suitably amended for his disabled needs. "Paki, writer, cripple: who am I now?" he asks. But the year of writing in hospital has helped him establish a new routine. With Carlo as amanuensis to fashion his blogs into a book is like collaborating on plays and movies with directors.

EXHUMING HIS PAST LIFE, KUREISHI MUSES ON LITERATURE, FRIENDSHIPS AND HIS CHANGED RELATIONSHIPS



It is also a brave act to sustain a memoir that seamlessly shifts between a fully lived past and a dependent present. "My world has taken a zig where previously it zagged; it has been smashed, remade and altered.... But I will not go under; I will make something of this." ■

—Sunil Sethi